

Puma yagouaroundi

Jaguarundi



Length 19–33 in
(48.5–83.5 cm)
Tail 11–33 in
(27.5–59 cm)
Weight 6½–17 lb
(3–7.6 kg)
Location S. USA to South
America
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



More mustelid than felid in overall proportions, with a pointed snout, long body, and shortish legs, the jaguarundi has several color forms of unpatterned fur, from black—mainly in forests—to pale gray-brown or red—in dry shrubland. This cat hunts by day, often on the ground, in habitats ranging from semiarid scrub to rain forest and swamp. Its main prey are birds, rodents, rabbits, reptiles, and invertebrates.



Puma concolor

Puma



Length 2¼–5¼ ft
(0.9–1.6 m)
Tail 23½–38 in
(60–97 cm)
Weight 75–160 lb
(34–72 kg)
Location W. and S. North
America, Central America,
South America
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Larger than some “big” cats, the puma—also called panther, cougar, or mountain lion—is probably related more closely to smaller cats. Most of

its fur is uniformly buff-colored. It makes many sounds, including an eerily humanlike scream when courting, but it cannot roar. Amazingly adaptable, the puma lives in habitats ranging from tropical rain forest, high mountains, and conifer forest to desert. Small mammals, such as mice, rats, rabbits, and hares, form the staple diet in many areas, as well as occasional sheep, young cattle, moose, and other livestock; the puma rarely scavenges. Births peak from February to September. The litter size ranges from 1–4 (average 2). The spotted cubs are born after a gestation of 92–96 days, in a den among rocks or in a thicket. They take solid food from 6–7 weeks.

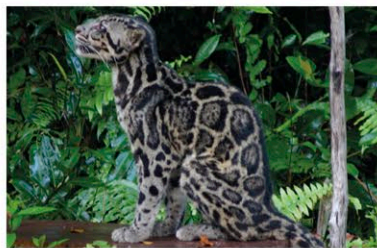


Neofelis diardi

Diard’s clouded leopard



Length 28–41 in
(70–105 cm)
Tail 23½–34 in
(60–85 cm)
Weight 22–55 lb
(10–25 kg)
Location S.E. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable



Diard’s clouded leopards range throughout Southeast Asia; those from Sumatra and Borneo were recently determined to be a separate species. They have smaller, darker “cloud” markings than those found on mainland Asia. Their numbers are estimated to be larger in Borneo (5,000–11,000) than Sumatra (3,000–7,000). They kill a wide range of prey from monkeys to fish and porcupines, and spend much of their time in trees.

Panthera pardus

Leopard



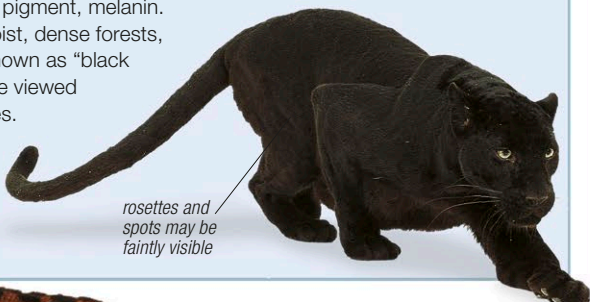
Length 3–6¼ ft
(0.9–1.9 m)
Tail 24–43 in
(60–110 cm)
Weight 46–160 lb
(21–71 kg)
Location W., C., S., E.,
and S.E. Asia, Africa
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable



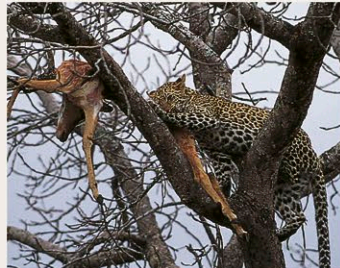
Few other wild cats are as varied in appearance or in prey preference as the leopard, or have a wider geographical range. Its varied diet includes small creatures, such as dung beetles, and large mammals many times its own weight, such as antelopes. A large victim may provide enough food for 2 weeks, although such kills are usually made about every 3 days, twice as often for a female with cubs. The average litter of 2 is born after 90–105 days’ gestation, and is cared for by the mother. Weaned by 3 months, they stay with her for a year or more, and siblings may associate for longer. Adaptable to human presence, leopards hunt to within a few miles of big cities, but numbers are falling due to various human activities.

BLACK PANTHER

Like many species of cats and other mammals, leopards may exhibit melanism. As a result of this genetic change (mutation), the skin and fur contain large amounts of the dark pigment, melanin. Most common in moist, dense forests, melanic leopards, known as “black panthers,” were once viewed as a separate species. In deserts, leopards are pale yellow; in grass, they are deeper yellow.



CACHING IN TREES



The leopard is an adept climber and uses its immense strength to drag its prey up into trees, for immediate consumption or for caching (hiding for future use). In the branches, it can eat undisturbed, and the meat is safe from scavenging hyenas and jackals.

HEAD AND SHOULDERS

The leopard’s large head houses powerful jaw muscles to bite, kill, and dismember prey. The shoulders and forelimbs are also heavily muscled, to hold down victims and drag or haul prey into trees.

